finally helped people realize what I had been through after two years of abuse.

I felt fantastic going back down to the dressing room to get ready for kick-off. When we came back out, I'd have run through a brick wall for my country. And, to be honest, that's what the Germany game felt like we were having to do: it was hard, really hard. The ninety-odd minutes were absolutely terrible as a game of soccer. But considering we hadn't beaten them in a competitive game since 1966, the result more than made up for that: England 1 Germany 0.

I'd set up our two goals against Portugal and was feeling pretty confident about my game. Just after half-time in Charleroi, we got a free-kick a couple of yards inside Germany's half. Gary Neville came running up to me:

'Take a quick one. Come on.'

You can't knock the bloke. Gary's always up for it, wanting to be involved, but just then I didn't want to just tap the ball to him and get back into open play.

'Gary, just go away.'

I don't think he was all that happy about me sending the free-kick long but I went ahead and did it anyway. It swung enough in the air to miss two German defenders and Alan Shearer ran on to it at the far post and stuck it in. It turned out to be the winning goal. In the middle of the celebrations, Gary came up alongside me:

'Great cross, Becks.'

Like it had been his idea all along. Gary drives you mad sometimes but I can't think of anyone I'd rather train or play soccer with. He's got a perfect attitude to the game. Once the final whistle had gone, we were all out celebrating on the field while the supporters were going crazy: we'd beaten Germany and won our first game of the tournament. I remember Gary, though, coming up to me and putting things into focus:

'We should get off the field. We haven't done anything yet. We haven't even qualified out of this group.'

And he was right. We still had Romania to play. We just needed a draw against them to go through from the group, but everybody knows now how